FACILITATING MEETINGS

Running an Efficient Meeting

Five practical adjustments for meetings that already have the right goal, people and format, but still run long and leave people frustrated.

What this resource is for

A meeting can already have the right goal, the right people, and the right format, and still run long and leave everyone frustrated. When that happens, the problem is usually in how the meeting is run rather than in what it is meant to achieve. Five practical adjustments help.

Five practical adjustments

Separating the facilitator from the content owner keeps the clock protected. When the same person is presenting the material and also managing the discussion and the time, timekeeping is usually the first thing to slip.

Agreeing the decision criteria before the meeting, rather than during it, stops a Decide meeting turning into a debate about what "good enough" looks like. If the group agrees the standard in advance, the meeting itself can focus on applying it to the options in front of them. Unclear decision criteria are one of the main causes of slow decisions.

Giving a recurring meeting a standing structure, the same shape every time, saves the time that would otherwise go into re-establishing the format at the start of each session. Novelty is expensive in a meeting that happens every week.

Defaulting to written input before open discussion, the same principle behind brainwriting, moves the live conversation from restating positions to actually resolving disagreement, since everyone has already read what everyone else thinks.

Closing with a short, explicit recap, what was decided, who owns the next step, and by when, prevents a meeting from trailing off without a clean end. A meeting that ends this way rarely needs a second meeting later just to re-establish what was agreed.

Online version with links to related resources: https://resources.simsab.net/effective-meetings/running-an-efficient-meeting

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